First, the stereotype. He was 16 when his parents bought him a used motorcycle as a Christmas gift. Learning to ride in the paddy fields of Shoranur, his hometown in Kerala's Palakkad district, the teenager was impressed by a bunch of riders practising for a race on a dirt track. A week later, Harith Noah was competing in his first race. Despite a good start, he came last. But the plot had turned.

Two years later, at 18, Noah had won the first of his five national supercross championships. On January 19, 2024, he finished the world's toughest rally raid, the Dakar, in 11th position, the highest-ever ranking by an Indian. He did not know that he had come first in the Rally2 category in which he was competing.

## A Master's Mindset

Noah does not follow his timings or his daily positions when he is racing. "My mental trainer and I believe it is best for me to not know," he says, speaking to INDIA TODAY from Shoranur, two days after his 30th birthday. "The Dakar is such a long race, there are so many things that can go wrong. The final result depends on so many variables. Some are controllable, others are not. I try to focus on only the next kilometre of riding. Wherever that gets me, that's where I deserve to be. I need to be happy with it."

Noah's voice is a laconic drone; all questions are answered in a flatline. He sounds so relaxed it seems he still doesn't know what he has achieved. In a country with the world's largest two-wheeler industry, he has roared to the summit of motorcycling excellence; in a sport viewed as the domain of adrenaline junkies, reckless to the point of being suicidal.

"Harith is a responsible person, a very responsible rider," says Vimal Sumbly, head of premium business at the TVS Motor Company. TVS recruited Noah after his first supercross win in 2011. "Racing is a mental game, it is not about adrenaline. Harith is a unique talent. He is energetic and inquisitive, trains very hard, and has a calm, meditative head on his shoulders," adds Sumbly.

## Breaking Out

In the early years, Noah's pit mechanic and manager was his father. "I enjoyed riding and wanted to get better, as good as those boys riding in the paddy fields. I wanted to slide the motorcycle and jump like them," he says. He was serious. After school, he entered a correspondence course in sports science from a UK university. That's where he met sports psychologist Neil Roach, now his mental trainer.

Interviewers sometimes ask him to take off his shirt to reveal a body fitting of an MMA fighter or an exponent of Kalaripayattu. Rallying demands extreme physical training. "I am my own fitness trainer. I draw from the course I studied," he says. He has trained at Red Bull's set-up for elite athletes in Los Angeles.

Rallying requires three basic quali-

**RALLYING REQUIRES PHYSICAL FITNESS, NAVIGATION SKILLS AND RIDING SKILLS. IN THE FIRST TWO, NOAH BELIEVES HE'S UP THERE WITH THE BEST**



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